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FREE NO 28

COUNTER INFORMATION

SEPT/OCT 1990

People power beating the state

AROUND 12 million people throughout Britain are refusing to pay the poll tax. 31% of those on the poll tax register in England and Wales did not pay their first two monthly bills.

In Scotland - where the tax was introduced in April 1989 - warrants for last year's bills are being issued against 800,000 non-payers, over 21% of those registered. More than 750,000 have not paid a penny of this year's poll tax. And these are the official figures - thousands more are not even registered.



31 March Poland: 40 demonstrators picket the British Embassy in Warsaw to protest against the poll tax. The demo was organised by the anarchist group RSA.

The Tories poll tax plan is to boost the bank balances of big business and the rich elite at the expense of the majority. They aim to concentrate more power in the hands of central government and force Councils to slash local services. But their scheme is seriously back-firing. Massive grass-roots refusal to pay is not only threatening Tory rule - it's implicitly challenging key aspects of the whole exploiting profit system.

ENGLAND & WALES RESIST

Non-payment is massive. 60% are not paying in Lambeth, 50% in Haringey and 48% in Hackney. In Birmingham, England's largest Council, 35% are non-payers. There is 50% non-payment in Norwich, Leeds and in Greater Tames-side (Manchester area), 40% in Liverpool, 39% in Bath.

After 3 months of the financial year Councils were a whopping £2.8 billion worse off than last year - largely due to non-collection of the poll tax. (Times 18/7)

In England and Wales the authorities must take non-payers to court before trying to recover the poll tax. It only needs a fraction of non-payers to contest the case and the wheels of injustice will come grinding to a halt.

Anti poll tax groups are organising for non-payers to be assisted in court by "unofficial lawyers". By asking countless

THE BURNING BUSH

THE INVASION and annexation of Kuwait by Iraq has provoked a response of economic and military blockade by the world's states.

The ruthless terrorising of the Iraqi population, the Genocide of the Kurds and the barbarism of the Iran-Iraq war, have characterised Saddam Hussain's ambitions of power through force. Massive debts generated by the Iran-Iraq war provided an economic motive to transfer Kuwaiti wealth and assets to Iraqi use. Few tears can be shed for the Kuwaiti Royal dynasty and the vast wealth they built up exploiting foreign workers (mostly from the Philippines and India) in the oil fields.

The ambitions of the US military complex is to permanently guarantee the security of the dynasty that rules Saudi Arabia and other Gulf states and with it their vast oil reserves. A military conflict between Iraq and the US could lead to the possible use of chemical and nuclear weaponry to achieve their aims. The recruitment of Jordanian citizens to volunteer for the Iraqi army in the advent of military clashes, could destabilise the corrupt reign of King Hussein and if Iraqi annexation or domination was achieved then Israel and Iraq would be directly facing each other across the River Jordan.

Any illusion of peace and tranquillity post cold war would be shattered as Middle East war led to possible global conflict drawing in Arab powers in support of Iraq. Militarism and capitalism are inseparable and can only be overthrown by social revolution.

questions court cases are spun out for as long as possible. In July it took one and a half hours to hear the single case of Jonathan Davies in Wandsworth. Accompanying this legal filibustering by mass demos at all cases could cause chaos!

In Warrington on 28 June 1,000 people took over the court - because of the demo no cases were dealt with. On 19 July 150 people tried to occupy the court again after the magistrates stopped people defending themselves.

200 people marched through Huddersfield and demonstrated at the courts on 26 July. About 50 of the 612 summonsed contested their cases and 23 had their summonses withdrawn or the case adjourned. Though liability orders were granted against 589 non-payers, **at the rate of 600 summonses per month it will take Kirklees Council nearly 7 years to get all the non-payers!**

1,000 demonstrated at the courts at Kirby on 1 August. Non-payers have besieged courts country-wide, including Isle of Wight, Goole, South Shields, Southend, Huyton, Northampton.

Tory Northampton council has been the first in England to send in the bailiffs, a firm called Madagans. However they have been getting a hot reception - especially when a firebomb gutted their offices causing £180,000 damage! In late July 30 people successfully protected Ian Bates home from the bailiffs.

It's important that the anti poll tax fight spreads to the workplace. Housing workers in Greenwich, London have been on strike since May after cashiers were suspended for refusing to collect the poll tax. The 160 NALGO workers have received great support, with thousands refusing to cross their picket. (contact Greenwich NALGO strike fund, NALGO, Love Lane, London SE 18)

At Hackney Council suspended worker Andy Murphy got his job back after strike action in his support. Andy had been victimised for speaking for Class War on TV in support of the Trafalgar Square demonstrators who resisted the police.

SCOTLAND RESISTS

In Strathclyde Region - Scotland's largest - £87 million of the '89-90 poll tax remains unpaid. Official non-payment is 22%. 520,000 non-payers have received warrants. The Sheriff Officers have been so unsuccessful that even their own press conference in Glasgow on 10 July was occupied by protestors!

On 6 August 50 people, angry at a recent pointing, surrounded a sheriff officers' car in Bellshill, by Glasgow. The car was damaged, and the sheriffs only escaped with police protection. **Later protestors occupied the sheriffs' premises - Stirling Park & Co in Glasgow - for 11 hours.** 39 were arrested. On 10 August 200 people successfully guarded 9 homes in Bellshill against pointings.

Anti poll tax protestors occupied the Social Security offices in Easterhouse and Anniesland in Glasgow to resist the

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CAN OF WORMS

THE CAMPAIGN for a Workers City against the marketing of Glasgow as the "City of Culture" has gathered remarkable momentum in a summer of discontent

An imaginative campaign on behalf of Elspeth King, the Curator of the Peoples' Palace in a dispute about a post of Keeper of Social History in the Museums Department uncovered a web of deceit and intimidation led by Pat Lally, Leader of the Labour District Council. The publicity and unmasking of

covert subsidies for the 1990 Cultural Extravaganza has now been linked with the issue of a proposed Council extended leasing of part of the Glasgow Green, a common land given to the citizens, to leisure developers, and resistance to new motorway plans affecting the Green.

A packed meeting on 3 August organised by 'Workers City' gave rise to calls for direct action to stop development. "The city is being run as though it were a public company having to operate in an expanding free market economy." (Jim Kelman). Lally's Labour realism is under threat from Glasgow citizens. On 7 August a Council meeting was invaded by 100 protestors who refused to delegate spokespersons.

Contact GLASGOW KEELIE, PO Box 239, Glasgow G3 6RA Send a SAE for the broadsheet and details of the Workers City Campaign.

Ohio Update

PRISON ACTIVIST JOHN PEROTTI remains in a sensory deprivation cell (ie. everything is white, uniform and sound-proofed) in Lebanon prison, OH. But there are plans to transfer him to a new Super Maximum isolation unit at Mansfield, OH, as soon as it opens. The protest letter campaign to the State governor may have been one of the reasons that he is still allowed a visitor a month, and he now gets exercise in the yard (tho' still in isolation). More of his mail is also getting through. To help add a human touch to his inhuman conditions readers are encouraged to send bright and cheery colour postcards to: John Perotti, Lebanon Correctional Institution, No 167712, PO Box 56, Lebanon, OH 45036. USA.



15 June, London: A "slave market" is held outside Victoria Rd. Employment Service to protest against the Government cheap labour schemes and increased harassment of claimants. The demo was organised by South East Region Anti Workfare Movement, and included Black Women for Wages for Housework.

Photo Sara Callaway

DOWN TO BASICS

"Now let's cut the crap ... What this is really about is forcing people off the register so that Mrs Fat Shit Face can get back for another term".

The Restart Interviewer paled. The claimant she was harassing in this Edinburgh Job Centre had just put his finger on the real motives behind the government's compulsory interviews for unemployed.

Claimants in Edinburgh and elsewhere are resisting restart harassment by going to interviews with an advisor/friend. The Claimants Union organises this, to ensure that the unemployed are not forced into the Job Club, the ET cheap labour scheme, etc.

Now the government has announced that later this year Restart courses (usually 1 week long) will be made compulsory for those unemployed over 2 years. Anyone sending the unemployed on such courses or running them had better get ready for a hot reception.

Info: Claimants Union c/o 103 Broughton St., Edinburgh. Tel. 031 557 0718.

Hassle news-sheet etc. from Federation of Claimants Unions and Unwaged Organisations, c/o Plymouth Claimants Union, PO Box 21, Plymouth.

Resist to Exist

IN CI 26 WE REPORTED on the racist murder of Kuldip Singh Sekhon, and the mass demonstration in November of his community in Southall. At the trial of his murderer, Steven Coker, the Southall Monitoring Group (an anti-racist group) organised a daily picket of the court to remind people of this racist murder. The judge tried to ban the picket as "sub-judice". At sentencing he repeatedly denied this was a racist murder.

CLAIMANTS TAKE OVER TREASURY

ON 7 APRIL New Zealand's labour government announced a package of truly Thatcher-esque benefit cuts: no benefits for under 18's, pensions cut, accident compensation reduced, and lower benefits for single people in shared accommodation.

Unemployment is a record 10.7%. Compulsory work interviews for the unemployed (like restart!) and a work for dole scheme are other government measures.

On 9 April claimants hit back by occupying the Government Treasury office in Auckland. Pickets of the Employers Federation and Labour party conferences were among other many other protests which followed.

From 10 to 12 July claimants groups planned to march on parliament in Wellington.

Info: Auckland Unemployed Workers Rights Centre, P.O. Box 68-488, Newton, Auckland, New Zealand.

NO RETURN

WORKERS BUILT STREET BARRICADES, occupied government buildings and closed Nicaraguas borders and airports during an 11 day general strike

The strike, backed by the Sandinistas, was in response to the US backed governments plan to sell off nationalised industries, dismantle the health service built under the previous Sandinista government, and introduce a harsh economic regime. Workers also demanded job security and higher wages to compensate for currency devaluation. 80,000 workers who began the strike on 2 July were soon joined by hundreds of thousands of people from other industries. The government conceded with a 45% wage rise, but the issue of privatisation remains.

Solidarity is a weapon

ONE PERSON HAS ALREADY DIED in a hunger strike in Spain involving members of GRAPO, and the PCE (r). Following the death of Jose Manuel Sevillano on 17 May people demonstrated outside a hospital in Carabanchel which holds other hunger strikers being force fed. GRAPO is the armed wing of the Communist Party of Spain (reformed). Recently they have fought against the torture and control used against political prisoners in Spain and other NATO/EC states. We support their resistance to oppression and their solidarity with other militant prisoners. However we reject their ideas of an armed elite vanguard as a means to change society.

The hunger strike which began on 30 Nov. demanded free association with other political prisoners and an end to the use of isolation as torture. 48 people still remained on hunger strike.

The hunger strike sparked a wave of solidarity and protest across Europe including demos in 12 different European cities. Relatives of W. German political prisoners disrupted an "anti torture committee" meeting at the EC parliament in Strasbourg on 5 April. The day following the death of Solidarity also came from prisoners in Spain, W. Germany, France, Belgium, USA, and Italy.

No frontiers for all!

WHILE the wall was falling between the two Germanies, the West German parliament was preparing new 'foreigner-laws', the first since 1965.

These laws will take effect from 1 January 1991, forming a legal wall around Germany designed to keep non-European Community foreigners out - a 'Germany for the Germans'.

One clause concerns political activity and it could prohibit the participation of foreigners in demonstrations. Any actions or protests against racist groups, parties or political programmes could be forbidden as they might "interfere with or endanger the development of political opinions and the peaceful co-existence of Germans and foreigners."

The residence permits of family members are now dependent on the status of the family member who arrived in W. Germany first (usually the husband). This effectively could mean women and children being forced to stay with an abusive man for fear of deportation if they leave.

France recently introduced a bill which is practically a word for word translation of this insidious law.

OUTRAGED

Since November there have been at least 3 racist murders in Berlin, harassment and intimidation of Turkish workers in W. Germany has become more widespread and organised. In one instance a Turkish worker on a picket line was shot at.

Outraged at the new laws and racist attacks people, especially school students, protested throughout W. Germany..

26 April : 200 pupils squatted their school for 24 hours. 12 students started a hungerstrike which lasted a few days.

27 April : More than 500 pupils demonstrated against fascism, racism, and the new foreigner laws.

12 May : On the day that the new law was put through, there were protests outside the institution of foreign affairs. 500 pupils from another school squatted it for 24 hours.

The same day 20,000 people marched in Frankfurt to protest at German unification. The demo was brutally attacked by cops with batons and 3 water cannons, but good organisation meant that the attacks didn't split up the demo.

Source : Info Bulletin, Hamburg

WINDS OF CHANGE!

Corrupt One Party States in Kenya and Zambia are under increasing threat from riots and opposition forces.

In Zambia IMF pressure forced up the price of Maize Meal in 1 month by 370%. 4 years after the riots forced the withdrawal of the last austerity package.

Student protests in central Lusaka spread to townships and squatter camps on the outskirts as thousands went on the rampage. "This is a full-time riot and live ammunition is being used", stated a Police Chief, with 30 dead in fierce clashes.

Troops were brought in from the east to quell the "anti-establishment riots". The Lusaka campus was occupied and closed, the Kuanda's ruling UNIParty launched a propaganda offensive stating multi-party = hooliganism. A planned referendum has been postponed to next year. "The forces of hate" as Kuanda nervously put it on 26th July, may not easily be suppressed.

In Kenya a similar revolt of shanty-dwellers threatened the regime of Moi and his KANU Party. Rioting spread from Nairobi to Nakuru, Nyeri and Naivaha.

By 31st July a crack-down led to the detention of opposition figures including dozens of people distributing "subversive music", cassettes about slum evictions and the murder of Dr. Ouko a former Foreign Minister.

With Western powers and the IMF now favouring pluralism and the veneer of Parliamentary Democracy in Africa, pressure has intensified to remove corrupt and tyrannical rulers.

DRAWING THE LINE

East German metalworkers in the cities of Erfurt, Jena and Gera staged a series of warning strikes and work stoppages in pursuit of their claim for a DM 400 (£130) weekly wage rise across the board, job security for two years and the introduction of a 40-hour working week.

THEIR SYSTEM, THEIR PROFITS OUR LIVES

The 6th International Conference on Aids, held this year in San Francisco and attended by 10,000 scientists and health workers, was blockaded by Act-Up - (Aids Coalition to Unleash Power).

Gay activists angry at drug companies making huge profits from Aids related drugs, at lack of state money for research and their blatant discrimination against those with the HIV virus, staged a week of action, leading to many arrests, and the threat of police opening fire.

On day 3 lesbians blocked a corner across from the Conference centre. Following a short march all hell broke loose. The police surrounding the lie-down protestors were pelted with missiles.

The humiliation of President Bush's Secretary for Health was a high point of the week. Delegates joined in after Act-up activists held up yellow cards saying "Turn your Back", and he was drowned out by cat-calls. His calls for unity were met by chants of "no more talk - we want action!"

More than 100 groups boycotted the Conference in protest at American law requiring those with HIV virus to get special permission to enter the States.

"The seropositive Ball", an 'alternative' conference supported by Act-up groups, was held in Holland to co-incide with the San Francisco Conference. Here activists exchanged info on science and actions.

OFF THE RAILS

Solidarnosc government ministers in Poland fear that a wave of unrest could "lead to Social anarchy".

After a rail strike in late May, Lech Walesa issued warnings of Civil War. Farmers' occupations of state buildings and roadblocks ensued in July.

With living standards cut by a third and Poland seen as a model for accelerated reform in the Soviet Union, patience and resignation could give way to an explosion of unrest if reform leads to permanent unemployment and austerity.

The difficulties of reforming centrally controlled economies in Eastern Europe and the USSR have been thrown into crisis with the disruption of oil supplies by workers unrest in Tyumen and ethnic unrest in Azerbaijan.

Undermining Austerity

IN OFFICE SINCE March 1990, President Collor of Brasil's plan to "liberalise" the economy and reduce inflation from 84% has had drastic effects on the people of Brasil. By June 33,000 workers had been dismissed, wages slashed and bank accounts frozen (businesses of course found ways of unfreezing the money). In May workers marched in protest, coal miners occupied state mine and bauxite workers occupied a MRN mine. On 2 June 150,000 port workers struck and on 26 June a pact between the government and unions to suspend strikes in return for a freeze on prices and dismissals failed. By the end of July half of the bank accounts had been released and the "liberalisation" plan seriously undermined.

Danish Blues

ON JUNE 11 400 anti-fascists demonstrated in Helsingor, Denmark at a meeting of European fascist MPs from France, Germany and Belgium. Anti-fascists confronted police, who kept them away from the hotel, with stones, paint bombs and other weapons. There were seven arrests.. Ekonomia (Denmark).

Occupied!

IN PROTEST at the continued killing of Kurds in Turkey during an uprising for self-government which has claimed 40 lives so far, 9 demonstrators occupied the Turkish airlines office in Copenhagen on 28 March. After an hour they were attacked by cops with teargas and batons, arrested, and held for 12 hours. : Ekonomia (Denmark).

Pensioners

IN VOJENS, DENMARK pensioners are fighting council cuts by refusing to return I.D cards which entitle them to half-price travel.. Ekonomia (Denmark).

BANANA REPUBLIC

Troops moved in and evicted on 4th August, about 10,000 striking workers who had occupied the grounds of a U.S. banana company for 41 days in a pay dispute. At least two workers were shot and two others were beaten when the army occupied property of Chiquita Brand International, a union spokesman said. The Honduran government gave the company permission to hire new workers to replace strikers.

Anti poll tax - cont. from p.1.

poll tax being deducted from the benefits of non-paying claimants. More needs to be done to encourage the DSS and UBO workers to defy management and the compromising Union leadership and refuse to implement benefit docking.

Anti poll tax groups successfully stopped the sheriff officers carrying out poindings in towns and villages throughout East and Midlothian in early June. Crowds defended non-payers homes in Prestonpans, Dunbar, Port Seaton, Pathhead, Tranent, Rosewell, and Penicuik. In Pathhead building workers stopped work and joined the protest. 60 - 100 people - including protestors from Morpeth in Northumberland - stood guard from 8am to 8pm, defying both sheriffs and police.

16 months of mass refusal to pay - and there has not been one warrant sale for non-payment of the poll tax in Scotland.

STOP THE AXEMEN

The anti poll tax movement has always warned that the poll tax was designed to decimate local services. Now Councils country-wide are threatening cuts - and blaming non-payers!

Anti poll tax groups, council workers and local residents in London took action in July against redundancies and service cuts. 2,800 NALGO workers struck in Haringey on 23 July. Haringey Anti Poll Tax Union were heavily involved in the 750 strong anti cuts protest at the Council. Brent Council was occupied and Hammersmith disrupted, while 500 council workers took strike action in Newham.

The claimants news-sheet **HASSLE** writes: "The Anti Poll Tax Unions must...build strong links NOW with workers whose jobs, and communities whose facilities are both under threat. Strikes, sit-ins, occupations will become necessary to defend jobs and services."

DROP THE CHARGES

Anti poll tax demonstrators resisted heroically when police attacked the 200,000 strong march in London on 31 March. But 409 people were arrested and charged that day, and over 100 since. The state is mounting a concerted attack designed to frighten and discredit the anti poll tax movement.

At 6am on 21 June 60 police wielding sledgehammers raided 6 homes in Hackney, London. 11 people were arrested. 4 were charged with violent disorder (charges against 3 have since been dropped).

Defendants are receiving unjust convictions and vicious sentences. On 26 July at Southwark Court. Judge Geoffrey Rivlin jailed Sean O'Reilly for 2 years for kicking a police van.

But the Trafalgar Square Defendants Campaign (TSDC) and the anti poll tax movement are fighting back. On 22 June and 13 July people protested against the Hackney raids at Bow St. court. 150 demonstrated at Pentonville Jail on 1 July. Prisoners unfurled a NO POLL TAX banner. 30 marched round Brixton Prison on 22 July, to cheers from banner-waving prisoners, and 45 protested at Wormwood Scrubs on 5 August. Demonstrators picketed Horseferry Rd courts on 30 July.

19/20 October - Solidarity Days of National and International Action with all poll tax defendants and prisoners. Protest in your area. Called by TSDC.

TSDC, Rm.205, Panther House, 38 Mount Pleasant, London WC1X 0AP Tel.071 833 8958 (200 anti poll tax groups now affiliated) Local solidarity groups include Sussex Poll Tax Resisters Support Fund Tel. 0273 671213

POLL TAX RIOT pamphlet £1 : Acab Press, BM 8884, London WC1N 3XX.

THE MOVEMENT

There are now thousands of local anti poll tax groups, with dozens of regional and city federations - all standing for mass non-payment.

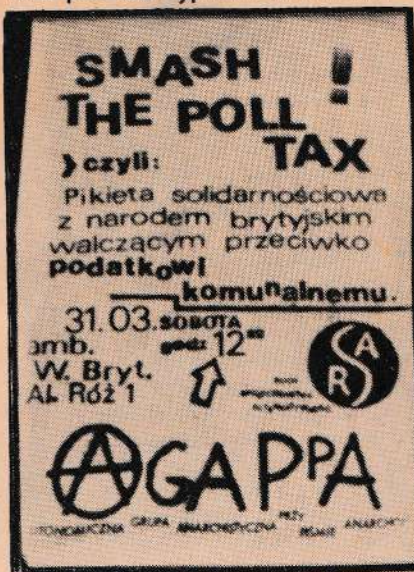
Anti Opt-Out

Over recent months, the NHS changes have begun to affect the service given to patients. The general thrust of these changes seems to be to break up the NHS into self-interested units in competition with each other.

The Leeds NHS Defence Campaign was set up to monitor how changes are af-

fecting NHS staff and patients, to inform people about what is happening and to organise against the government's moves. They are presently campaigning against the opt-out of local Leeds hospitals and ward closures. They have produced an information leaflet which can be obtained from Sean Quigley, COHSE Branch Sec, Porters Room, LEEDS GENERAL INFIRMARY.

Anti poll tax flyposter in Warsaw



With Labour councils country-wide pursuing non-payers, the way forward is to build up grass-roots 'counter power' in the communities and workplaces - independent from, and in opposition to, all political parties and the state.

But Militant persist in seeking compromise and respectability within the Labour Party. The Militant All Britain Federation leaders want the Glasgow-London Peoples March Against the Poll Tax to dissolve into meetings and rallies when it reaches London in October - Militant fear another uncontrollable outburst of class anger, as on 31 March. **Now the Trafalgar**

Square Defendants Campaign have called a national march through London on 20 October, from Trafalgar Sq. to the festival for the Peoples March in Brixton. They have asked London Federation to co-organise it.

The independent strand within the anti poll tax movement is becoming stronger, with the 3D and Refuse and Resist publications and the successful 3D conference in Sheffield and Scottish Anti Poll Tax Forum in Stirling, in June.

3D conference Leeds Sat. 15 Sept. tel. 081 808 5893 for details. 3D, 116 The Avenue, London N17 6DG

Refuse and Resist, c/o Murray, 31 Leven St., Glasgow G41 2JD

VICTORY - AND MORE

The anti poll tax movement - a historic citizens movement, larger than any comparable campaign in Britain this century - is on course for eventual victory and a refreshing success for people power against the state.

And what then? A Labour government is pledged to abolish the poll tax - but what about the millions who will owe massive arrears? The anti poll tax movement will have to rise to the challenge and fight for all poll tax arrears to be written off - Lothian Federation has already adopted this position. The likelihood is that for years millions will find themselves in direct conflict with the state and all political parties - a situation in which the struggle could generalise into a more conscious challenge to the whole system where an elite monopolises society's resources for their own gain. **Reclaim the world!**

STRIKING OIL! STRIKING OIL! STRIKING OIL!

AS WE went to press oil workers throughout the North Sea were taking industrial action. They were fighting for improved health & safety & Union recognition.

On 5 August over 7,000 contract workers on more than a 100 offshore installations took part in the 24 hour strike called by the unofficial Offshore Industry Liaison Committee. The strike was in support of thousands of workers sacked after an earlier 24 hour stoppage. (A 4th one day strike is now on).

When the employers tried to clear the oilfields workers hit back with sit-ins on the offshore installations. By 12 August 8 sit-ins were underway. 400 workers were on the 10th day of sit-ins in Shell's Brent Field.

The struggle spread onshore when 3,000 engineering workers stopped work for 24 hours on 9 August. McDermotts, Ardesier; Davy Offshore, Dundee; and the St Fergus gas terminal by Peterhead were all shut down.

The dispute escalated further as 400 workers in the southern sector of the North Sea launched an indefinite strike. However OILC Chair Ronnie MacDonald ordered a return to work.

600 workers have died and countless been maimed in the last 25 years. The companies have always put profit before safety.

Only by spreading and stepping up the action as much as possible, and only by asserting workers collective power rather than relying on gaining Union recognition, will the offshore workers be able to stop the slaughter in the North Sea.

Info from oil workers news-sheet Blowout, 52 Guild St, Aberdeen AB1

COUNTER INFORMATION, PIGEONHOLE CI, C/O 11 FORTH ST, EDINBURGH, UK. For info on local CI distribution and other local activities write: For the north of England - Counter Information c/o 52 Call Lane Leeds. West of Scotland - Glasgow Anarchists, PO Box 239, Glasgow G3 6RA This issue went to press 13 August 1990.

Thanks to all who donated to our appeal. More standing orders are still needed to sustain C.I. - please write for a standing order form.